AFRICAN UNION (AU)

The Organization of African Unity (OAU) or Organization de l'Unité Africaine (OUA) was established on 25 May 1963. It was disbanded on 9 July 2002 by its last Chairperson, South African President Thabo Mbeki, and replaced by the African Union by the Sirte Declaration to boost and accelerate the African unity and efforts of integration in the context of the challenges posed by globalization. The AU consists of 53 African States. However, 4 member states, Guinea (2008), Madagascar (2009), Eritrea (2009) and Côte d'Ivoire (2010) have been suspended.

When the OAU was formed, it had two primary aims:

- To promote the unity and solidarity of the African states and act as a collective voice for the African continent. This was important to secure Africa's long-term economic and political future. Years of colonialism had weakened it socially, politically and economically.
- The OAU was also dedicated to the eradication of all forms of colonialism, as, when it was established, there was still a number of states that had not yet won their independence or were minority-ruled. South Africa and Angola were two such countries. The OAU proposed two ways of ridding the continent of colonialism. First, it would defend the interests of the independent countries and help pursue those of still-colonized ones. Second, it would remain neutral in terms of world affairs, preventing its members from being controlled once more by outside powers.

The AU has also been formed with certain purposes and principles in mind. These are reflected in the objectives of the AU.

The objectives of the AU are manifold such as to:

1. Achieve greater unity and solidarity between the African countries and the people of Africa.
2. Defend the sovereignty, territorial integrity and independence of its member states.